

Kodama of the East Tree // Kamahl, Heart of Kroa

Mono-green Commander, 100 cards. Partner commanders. How to actually play it.

Start here: what Kodama really does

Almost every mistake with this deck comes from reading Kodama as a landfall card. It is not. Read the trigger condition again, slowly:

*"Whenever **another permanent you control enters**, if it wasn't put onto the battlefield with this ability, you may put a permanent card with **equal or lesser mana value** from your hand onto the battlefield."*

Six things that follow from that wording

- 1. Any permanent. Not just lands.** Creatures, artifacts, enchantments, and every single token. A Clue from Tireless Tracker triggers it. An Insect from Scute Swarm triggers it. A Plant from Avenger of Zendikar triggers it. This is why token makers, not ramp spells, are the engine of the deck.
- 2. The mana value gate is set by what entered,** not by what you want to drop. A permanent with mana value 4 enters, you may put something of mana value 4 or less onto the battlefield from hand.
- 3. Lands have mana value 0.** They have no mana cost, so their mana value is zero. That means **every single Kodama trigger, no matter how small, can put a land from your hand onto the battlefield.** Even a vanilla 1/1 Insect token clears the bar.
- 4. It puts the card onto the battlefield, it does not play it.** So a land dropped this way does **not** use your land drop for the turn, and it ignores the one-land-per-turn rule entirely. It also means the card is never cast, so it can't be countered.
- 5. The anti-loop clause.** A permanent that Kodama itself put onto the battlefield will not trigger Kodama again. That is what stops this being infinite. **But it still triggers landfall** and every other enters-the-battlefield effect you control, which is where the value comes from.
- 6. It says "may."** You can always decline. Declining matters more than it sounds - see the misplays page.

Token mana values (memorise this bit)

A plain token with no mana cost is mana value 0, so it only ever lets Kodama drop a land. A token that is a **copy** of a card copies that card's mana cost, so it carries that card's mana value.

Token	Mana value	What Kodama can put down off it
Insect (Scute Swarm, under 6 lands)	0	A land, and nothing else
Scute Swarm copy (6+ lands)	3	Any permanent MV 3 or less
Plant (Avenger of Zendikar)	0	A land
Beast (Rampaging Baloths, Primeval Bounty)	0	A land

Token	Mana value	What Kodama can put down off it
Bear (Dancing from Dark to Dawn)	0	A land
Clue (Tireless Tracker)	0	A land
Zabu (Ka-Zar)	0	A land

The free-land chain

This is the core loop of the deck and it runs off any token maker plus lands in hand. Using Scute Swarm as the example:

1. You play a land normally. Two things trigger: Scute Swarm's landfall, and Kodama (the land entered, and Kodama didn't put it there).
2. Kodama's trigger resolves. The land was mana value 0, so you may put a mana value 0 permanent from hand onto the battlefield - another land. **This does not use your land drop.**
3. Scute Swarm's landfall resolves and makes a token.
4. That second land entering triggers landfall **again** (another Scute token) but does **not** re-trigger Kodama, because Kodama put it there.
5. Each Scute token entering **does** trigger Kodama, because the token was made by Scute Swarm's ability, not Kodama's. Each of those triggers puts another land from hand onto the battlefield.
6. Back to step 4. The chain continues until you run out of lands in hand.

The takeaway: every land in your hand is worth a landfall trigger, a token, and another Kodama trigger. Holding lands in hand is not flood in this deck - it is ammunition. Do not dump your hand of lands before you have a token maker on the battlefield.

Scute Swarm, and why it doubles

*"Landfall - Whenever a land you control enters, create a 1/1 green Insect creature token. **If you control six or more lands, create a token that's a copy of this creature instead.**"*

Two completely different cards depending on your land count. Under six lands it makes vanilla 1/1 Insects with no abilities. At six or more it makes **copies of itself**, and each copy has the same landfall trigger. Nothing happens when Scute Swarm enters - it pays off on your next land, not on arrival.

Land entering	Swarms that trigger	Copies made	Total Swarms
7th	1	1	2
8th	2	2	4
9th	4	4	8
10th	8	8	16

Land entering	Swarms that trigger	Copies made	Total Swarms
11th	16	16	32

"A land entering" is far broader than your one land drop per turn. It includes:

- Extra drops from Exploration (+1), Azusa (+2), Loot (+1).
- **Burgeoning, which fires on opponents' turns** - every time an opponent plays a land you may put one from hand onto the battlefield.
- Lands your ramp puts onto the battlefield: Sakura-Tribe Elder, Cultivate, Nature's Lore, Three Visits, and **Blighted Woodland, which fetches two - two separate triggers.**
- **Fetchlands are two triggers each.** Windswept Heath and Verdant Catacombs enter (trigger one), then you crack them and the Forest enters (trigger two) - untapped, both on the same turn.
- Demolition Field, which lets you fetch a basic onto the battlefield when you blow up their land.
- Every land Kodama puts down off the chain above.

With Azusa out you get three land drops a turn, which is 1 Swarm to 8 to 64 across two turns. Practical note: they are all identical with no counters on them, so track them with one die showing the count rather than a die per token.

Kamahl, your second commander

"At the beginning of combat on your turn, creatures you control get +3/+3 and gain trample until end of turn. {1}{G}: Until end of turn, target land you control becomes a 1/1 Elemental creature with vigilance, indestructible, and haste. It's still a land."

The first ability is a free Overrun every single turn. Same +3/+3, same trample, same duration - but repeatable, and always available from the command zone. That is why the actual Overrun card was cut from the deck; it was a 5-mana one-shot copy of something you already do for free.

The second ability is better than it looks. The animated land is a 1/1 with vigilance, **indestructible**, and haste, and it is still a land. Uses:

- Extra attackers that Kamahl's own +3/+3 immediately turns into 4/4 tramlers.
- Surprise blockers at instant speed, and they are indestructible so they survive the block.
- An indestructible body that walks through a board wipe based on destroying creatures.
- With Seedborn Muse untapping your lands every turn, you can animate and block on every opponent's turn.

Animating a land does **not** trigger Kodama or landfall. The land is already on the battlefield; nothing entered.

The nine landfall triggers

Every land that enters checks all of these at once. Know the list so you sequence correctly.

Card	What each land entering does
Scute Swarm	Insect token, or a copy of itself at 6+ lands
Rampaging Baloths	A 4/4 Beast token

Card	What each land entering does
Dancing from Dark to Dawn	A 2/2 Bear token (and X counters on a creature whenever you cast a creature spell)
Avenger of Zendikar	Optional +1/+1 counter on each Plant you control
Ka-Zar's Zabu token	A +1/+1 counter on Zabu
Lotus Cobra	One mana of any color (use it, it empties)
Tireless Tracker	Investigate - a Clue, which is an artifact, so another Kodama trigger
Courser of Kruphix	Gain 1 life
Primeval Bounty	Gain 3 life

Sequencing rule: get the token makers down *before* you start dumping lands. A land played with Scute Swarm, Baloths and Dancing from Dark to Dawn all on the battlefield is three tokens and three extra Kodama triggers. The same land played on an empty board is one Kodama trigger and nothing else.

The engines

Temur Sabertooth - the toolbox engine

*"{1}{G}: You may return another creature you control to its owner's hand. **If you do**, this creature gains indestructible until end of turn."*

It makes every enters-the-battlefield effect in the deck repeatable, and every recast is another Kodama trigger. The indestructible is conditional - no bounce, no indestructible.

Bounce and recast	Cost per loop	What you get
Reclamation Sage	{1}{G} + {2}{G}	Destroy another artifact or enchantment
Eternal Witness	{1}{G} + {1}{G}{G}	Another card back from the graveyard
Woodland Bellow	{1}{G} + {4}{G}{G}	Another tutor - a different answer each time
Avenger of Zendikar	{1}{G} + {5}{G}{G}	A whole new wave of Plants
Ka-Zar	{1}{G} + {4}{G}	A fresh look at the top of your library

It is also protection: in response to targeted removal, bounce the creature being targeted and the spell fizzles.

Woodland Bellow - what to go get

Finds a **nonlegendary green creature, mana value 3 or less, put onto the battlefield**. That is two Kodama triggers off one card. All eleven legal targets:

Target	MV	Take it when
Scute Swarm	3	Default in a long game - you are at 6+ lands already, so it copies immediately
Reclamation Sage	3	There is an artifact or enchantment worth killing right now

Target	MV	Take it when
Eternal Witness	3	Your graveyard is better than your library
Tireless Tracker	3	Grinding - every Clue is also a Kodama trigger
Courser of Kruphix	3	You want lands off the top and a 2/4 blocker
Lotus Cobra	2	Still climbing toward the top end
Sakura-Tribe Elder	2	You need a landfall trigger on demand, or a chump block
Managorger Hydra	3	Long game, lots of spells being cast by everyone
Sylvan Safekeeper	1	Targeted removal is coming and you must save something
Llanowar Elves / Elvish Mystic	1	Almost never off a 6-drop

Bollower cannot find Temur Sabertooth (MV 4), Silverback Elder (MV 5), Beast Whisperer (MV 4), or any legendary creature. For the big things use **Green Sun's Zenith** (any green creature MV X or less, legendary included) or **Finale of Devastation** (any creature MV X or less, from library or graveyard).

More engines

Unnatural Growth plus Kamahl - get the order right

*"At the beginning of **each** combat, double the power and toughness of each creature you control until end of turn."*

Each combat means every opponent's combat too, not just yours. If you have only been doubling on your own turn you are playing half the card - your blockers double when you are attacked, which makes attacking into your board a terrible idea.

On your turn both Unnatural Growth and Kamahl trigger at the beginning of combat. You control both, so you choose the order they go on the stack, and **the stack resolves last on, first off**. You want Kamahl's +3/+3 counted before the doubling:

Put **Unnatural Growth's trigger on the stack first, Kamahl's on top**. Kamahl resolves first.
 Right order: Kodama 6/6 - Kamahl - 9/9 - doubled - **18/18**.
 Wrong order: Kodama 6/6 - doubled - 12/12 - Kamahl - 15/15.
 Three power per creature, across your whole board, every combat.

Counter doubling

The Earth Crystal replaces counters being put on any creature you control with twice that many. It applies to enters-the-battlefield counters too, which people forget:

- **Yorvo** normally enters with four +1/+1 counters. With Earth Crystal he enters as an **8/8**.
- **Kalonian Hydra** normally enters with four. With Earth Crystal it enters as an **8/8**, and then doubles the counters on your whole team every time it attacks.

- Earth Crystal's first line also makes every green spell you cast cost {1} less, which is the real reason it is in the deck.

Greater Good

"Sacrifice a creature: Draw cards equal to the sacrificed creature's power, then discard three cards." Two jobs: convert a huge creature into a fistful of cards, and save a creature from exile-based removal by sacrificing it in response. Multani is the ideal fodder - he is enormous and he returns himself from the graveyard later.

Growing Rites of Itlimoc

Cast as a {2}{G} enchantment, so it takes a spell slot, not a land slot. The enchantment entering is a Kodama trigger. It transforms at the beginning of your end step once you control four creatures - one Scute Swarm turn does that - and the back face taps for {G} per creature you control. Note the transform is **not** a land entering, so it gives no landfall trigger and no second Kodama trigger. Don't count on one.

Seedborn Muse

Untaps all your permanents during every other player's untap step. That means full mana on every turn of the table: Kamahl animating blockers, Temur Sabertooth bouncing in response to removal, Bonders' Enclave drawing a card, Burgeoning putting lands down on their turns. It is the single best card to protect.

Land utilities people forget

Land	The thing you keep forgetting
Castle Garenbrig	{2}{G}{G}, tap: add SIX green for creature spells or creature abilities
Mosswort Bridge	Play the hidden card for FREE at 10 total power - trivial after Kamahl's +3/+3, and you can activate it mid-combat once that trigger has resolved. Aim it at Craterhoof or Ulamog
Windswept Heath / Verdant Catacombs	Two landfall and two Kodama triggers each, both on the turn you play them
Itlimoc, Cradle of the Sun	Back face of Growing Rites. Taps for {G} per creature - after a Scute turn that is absurd
Rogue's Passage	Makes one doubled trampler unblockable - often lethal on its own
Blighted Woodland	Fetches TWO basics - two landfall triggers off one activation
Boseiju, Who Endures	Channel from hand kills an artifact, enchantment or nonbasic land
War Room	Mono-green means the life cost is only 1 per card

Misplays to stop making

- **Forgetting Kodama triggers off tokens.** This is the big one. Every Insect, Plant, Beast, Elemental, Clue and Zabu that enters is a Kodama trigger and at minimum a free land from hand.
- **Playing Unnatural Growth as a my-turn-only effect.** It doubles your creatures on every opponent's combat as well.
- **Getting the Unnatural Growth / Kamahl stack order backwards.** Costs you 3 power per creature.

- **Emptying your hand of lands too early.** Lands in hand are Kodama fuel. Hold them until a token maker is on the battlefield.
- **Expecting a second Zabu.** Zabu is a **legendary** token. Bouncing and recasting Ka-Zar while Zabu is alive does not net a second one - the legend rule makes you bin one, and you keep the original with its counters. You do still get the Kodama trigger and a fresh Ka-Zar enters-the-battlefield.
- **Expecting Silverback Elder to trigger off free permanents.** It only triggers when you **cast** a creature spell. It misses everything Kodama puts down, every token, and everything Woodland Bellower, Green Sun's Zenith and Finale of Devastation put onto the battlefield.
- **Paying {1}{G} to Temur Sabertooth with no other creature out.** The indestructible only happens if you actually return a creature.
- **Attacking with Rhonas without a 4-power friend.** Rhonas cannot attack or block unless you control another creature with power 4 or greater.
- **Forgetting Nylea is often not a creature.** Below five devotion to green she is not a creature and cannot attack - but her trample-granting ability works the whole time regardless.
- **Letting Ulamog get countered and mourning it.** "When you **cast** this spell, exile two target permanents" resolves even if the creature itself is countered. You still get the removal.
- **Not declining a Kodama trigger.** It says "may." If your only card in hand is a land you need for your natural drop later, or you are holding Heroic Intervention, think before dumping it.

Mulligan and opening

Keep hands with three or four lands and a cheap accelerant - Sol Ring, a mana dork, Exploration, Burgeoning, or Nature's Lore / Three Visits. Extra lands in hand are genuinely good here because of the Kodama chain, so a five-land hand with a token maker is fine.

Mulligan hands with no green source, hands with only expensive cards, and hands with no way to use the lands you are holding. A hand of seven with no permanent under four mana is a mulligan even in a ramp deck.

Priority of early plays: mana first (dork, Sol Ring, Exploration), then a cheap landfall payoff (Lotus Cobra, Scute Swarm, Tireless Tracker), then Kodama. Casting Kodama into an empty board with no cards in hand does very little; the commander is a multiplier, not a start.

How the deck actually wins

- **Craterhoof Behemoth** after a Scute Swarm or Avenger of Zendikar turn. It has haste itself and gives your whole team +X/+X and trample where X is your creature count. This is the standard kill.
- **Finale of Devastation for X of 10 or more** - finds a creature **and** gives your entire board +X/+X and **haste**. That haste clause is the only way your freshly made Scute tokens attack the same turn. Remember it.
- **Kamahl plus Unnatural Growth** as a grinding kill. +3/+3 then doubled, every combat, with trample.
- **Rogue's Passage** on one doubled trampler when the board is gummed up.
- **Ulamog** as the long-game plan when nothing else has stuck.

The one sentence version: land token makers first, then start converting the lands in your hand into free permanents through Kodama, then pump the resulting board with Kamahl and kill with Craterhoof or Finale. Kodama triggers on **everything**, so count your triggers before you pass priority.